

# Introduction

## *On War, Disability, and Refugee Life*

Throughout my life, I have heard my mother tell and retell the story of my birth. In 1979, my mother, father, and two young brothers escaped from Cambodia, barely surviving after living through four years of deprivation under the rule of the Khmer Rouge. They made it to a refugee camp called Chumrum Thmei (New Camp), located on the Cambodian side of the border. The genocide was over, but the war continued among political factions. Every day, a Red Cross bus arrived in the morning to transport a caravan of people across the border. When the bus arrived on one particular morning, my parents were determined to get on it. They sensed an imminent danger and knew the time had come to pick up and leave, yet again. In a crowd of refugees pushing forward, they jostled in front of the bus in hopes of being selected. Knowing the sick and the pregnant were being given priority, my mother showed her eight-months-pregnant belly to the Red Cross workers and managed to secure a spot for our family.

After a sixteen-hour journey, the bus arrived at Khao-I-Dang Holding Center, a sprawling camp inhabited by over one hundred thirty thousand people. Soon after they got off the bus, my mother and father heard the news about the attack on Chumrum Thmei: The night before, just after my family had boarded the Red Cross bus, Khmer Rouge soldiers arrived at the camp without warning. They burned the camp to the ground, turning it to nothing but rubble and ash. Everyone my mother and father knew at that camp was killed, captured, or subjected to worse horrors. It shamed them to marvel at

their luck in making it out yet again, but they felt as though they had crossed into a new life in reaching Khao-I-Dang.

When my mother would tell this story to people when I was growing up, she liked to emphasize the part about my presence in her womb. “I think it is because of Y-Dang, because I was pregnant with her. That’s why we got lucky.” In Khmer, giving birth is referred to as *chlong tonle* (ឆ្លងទន្លេ) meaning to “cross a river.”

My mother gave birth to me in Khao-I-Dang (เขาสีไล) about one month after our arrival there. With no real doctors, hospitals, or medicine, my mother labored for hours to bring me into this world. She remembers how my aunt was the person who cut my umbilical cord, the severed tether that meant I had passed through the difficult journey into life. In Thai, Khao (เขា) means mountain. I-Dang (สีไล) is the name of the mountain near the camp. The camp takes the name of the mountain. Khao-I-Dang. Nickname: KID. My mother and father chose the name I-Dang for me. On the refugee papers, my name was transliterated from Thai to English as Y-Dang. Y-Dang Troeung. In English, my name is pronounced e-dang trung. Y-Dang Troeung. How heavy it has been to carry this with me. And yet, this name (張依蘭; ទ្រីងអ៊ីដាង; Y-Dang Troeung), mom and dad always remind me, carries the memory of our multiple crossings.

*Refugee Lifeworlds* is a book about refugee life in the aftermath of the Cold War in Cambodia; it scrutinizes this topic from a specific angle. As in Figure I.1, taken in the refugee camp where I was born, this angle extends up from the ground of Cambodian refugee history. In the background, the mountains of Khao-I-Dang loom, forming a picturesque backdrop for six refugees (my mother, me, an unknown girl, and three other members of my extended family). A story of pain subtends and saturates this image—death, illness, disappearance, starvation, forced marriage, child loss, and so much more. But what is pictured here is not a portrait of suffering. It is an image of serendipitous reencounter and reconstituted, ephemeral family—of a mother’s fleeting instance of joy born out of a chance encounter with another Cambodian refugee wielding a Polaroid camera. What mother would not want a photo—at least one photo—of her new baby in that fragile first year? From this vantage point of fragmented family history, I set out in this book to explore how the Cambodian refugee archive offers alternative ways of knowing, sensing, and imagining the refugee afterlives of war.

In places such as Cambodia, where the archive has been shattered and is still in the process of being restored and rebuilt, conventional scholarly methods do not suffice. For refugee-scholars, such as myself, it is important



**Figure I.1** My mother holding me at nine months of age with cousins at Khao-I-Dang (KID) Holding Centre, Thailand, September 1, 1980 (person second-to-left unknown). (Courtesy of the Troeung family. Photo credit unknown.)

to honor and respect the knowledge that has been passed down to us by our families and community. Some of these stories that we carry are never meant to be heard outside of the family or the community, while some others, if curated with care, might begin to genuinely move and circulate in the world with the force of transformation. It is a delicate ground that we must carefully navigate. Those of us in the 1.5 or second generation of the Cambodia diaspora, like myself, hold the knowledge that just a few decades ago, our families lived through a war and genocide that the world scarcely remembers. Cambodian American author Monica Sok has written about the kind of struggles with language that we grapple with as the children of Cambodian survivors: “As a poet,” Sok writes, “I’m afraid of misrepresenting my family’s stories, the general history as well—though I believe the risk of going there is greater than fear. A big part of me is afraid of perpetuating the brutality through language.”<sup>1</sup> Channeling Audre Lorde’s assertion that “we can learn to work and speak when we are afraid in the same way we have learned to work and speak when we are tired,” Sok affirms, in the end, the importance of “going toward that silence” as a means of transforming what terrifies and immobilizes her.<sup>2</sup> Like Lorde and Sok, I also believe in the risk of going toward that space of fear and silence. But I have also struggled with the process of writing and rewriting draft after draft of my book in a cycle of fury, depression,

exhaustion, illness, self-doubt, inspiration, depression, and inspiration again. We labor tirelessly in the hope and fear of getting it “right,” realizing only in hindsight that this goal is impossible. We supposedly live with the imprint of epigenetic trauma in our genes. We fear passing it on to our children. We know intimately what it is like to live our lives with a kind of debilitating silence, an aphasia, coupled with an ever-present knowledge that carrying our silence for too long will shatter us or, to use Lorde’s metaphor, “choke us” from within. But we also know something else: that what we carry cannot be reduced to a defective history, psychology, or genetic profile; that it is possible to speak through silence, to use the pieces of our fragmented past to remake new worlds.

To this end, *Refugee Lifeworlds* interrupts the conventional expectations of scholarly writing and experiments with a method of autotheory that melds critical theory, autobiography, and textual analysis. A term popularized with the publication of Maggie Nelson’s *The Argonauts*, “autotheory,” according to Lauren Fournier, is the integration of the autobiographical self “with philosophy or theory, often in ways that are direct, performative, or self-aware.”<sup>3</sup> Autotheory is the inscription of the self into one’s scholarship and theoretical pursuits, a mode of writing that intentionally disrupts the expectations of the “distanced” and “objective” scholar via their object of study. It entails turning toward, not away from, our own lived experiences of colonialism, race, gender, refuge-seeking, survival, and family inheritance as sources of knowledge. As Barbara Christian influentially stated in 1988, people of color have always theorized, “but in forms quite different from the Western form of abstract logic.”<sup>4</sup> What constitutes “theory” must always be responsive and responsible to the shifting material and geopolitical conditions and crises of any given time and place, since, for too long, “theory” has operated as “a commodity that helps determine whether we are hired or promoted in academic institutions—worse, whether we are heard at all.”<sup>5</sup> As Ocean Vuong, author of the critically acclaimed novel *On Earth We’re Briefly Gorgeous*, asserts, “A writer of color does not arrive at the literary table, as is often believed, *in spite* their geographical and cultural roots, but *because* of them.”<sup>6</sup> Viewing his “origins” as a rich and creative foundation to his artistic praxis, Vuong gives value to the (queer) refugee’s epistemic standpoint as a creative force. While not something to be seen as exceptional or privileged in any way, this refugee lens on the world is an opening rather than a shackling of the imagination.<sup>7</sup>

The racialized gendered self’s experience as a foundation rather than a barrier to theory marks a long genealogy of autotheory by Indigenous and feminist writers and writers of color.<sup>8</sup> For writers of color, autotheory often emerges out of the need to write the self in response to the emotions of rage, anger, and madness that percolate within but that are made from without.

Autotheory offers a lifeline toward other people of color and other allies with whom we can safely share the space of negation, forging alternative futures together, without hurtling toward self-annihilation. As Cathy Park Hong asserts in her book of autotheory, *Minor Feelings*, we write because we “don’t want to be left stranded in [the] rage” that accrues from living in a system of pervasive racial violence.<sup>9</sup> In order to write so that we do not lose ourselves in what Frantz Fanon called the “infernal circle” in our minds,<sup>10</sup> every chapter of this book, including this Introduction, is bookended by autotheoretical and curated family stories—fragments, anecdotes, sketches, vignettes—as a way of approaching that space of silence, where historical, theoretical, and scholarly languages have failed to reach.

## Refugee Lifeworlds

The anecdotes that help me knit together the complex fabric of this book emerge from the texture and temporalities of refugee life as embodied and inherited experience. The category of the “refugee” is undoubtedly a flawed and limited term, one that emerges from liberal imperial technologies of governance designed to police the boundaries of when, how, and who is granted asylum and thus accorded legibility by the settler-colonial nation-state. As I have already alluded to in the Preface, in these legal-bureaucratic lexicons, the refugee is defined as a person who is outside of his or her country of origin owing to a “well-founded fear of being persecuted because of his or her race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group or political opinion.”<sup>11</sup> As an idiom of administrative power, a refugee is situated within a continuum of displaced positionalities, such as an internally displaced person, an asylum seeker, a migrant, and an undocumented person, all of which depend on the upholding of the illegitimate nation-state border itself. Moreover, the descriptor of “refugee” rarely emerges from the lives and vocabularies of displaced peoples themselves. It does not describe the refugee’s own ontology but rather names their function within a universalized idiom of human rights. The question of “who is a refugee” has been discussed at length by scholars, and so it is not my goal to rehearse those debates of taxonomy here.<sup>12</sup>

Instead, I explore in this book the conditions of possibility that the category of the refugee enables for those of us who have been named and disciplined by this label and thus by the state. We are not refugees because we ever wanted to be. Rather, we carry this label because it has been foisted on us over and over again, shaping and directing our routes and trajectories, our legibility within the settler-colonial nation-state, and the parameters of what is permissible or impermissible for us to speak about. In Canada, the





**Figure I.2** Y-Dang (eleven months old) waves a Canadian flag for the camera as Canadian Minister of Citizenship and Immigration Lloyd Axworthy welcomes Cambodian refugees to Canada in 1980 in a government arranged photo op. (Courtesy of the Troeung family. Photo credit unknown.)

figure of the refugee has played a particularly important role in the nation's structure of exaltation, deployed to the detriment of other minority groups in Canada, including Black and Indigenous peoples, who are persistently cast as "the undeserving poor" in opposition to the "poor deserving Asian refugee." I have witnessed firsthand the Canadian state's exaltation of my own "refugee image" for the consolidation and shoring up of white liberal multiculturalism. Arriving in Canada as the designated "last" refugee of the Canadian government's Special Indochinese Refugee Program in the 1980s, I became a poster child for this program<sup>13</sup> (see Fig. I.2). Of course, anyone in my position would rather be "saved" than left behind to die in a genocide or refugee camp, but the question of my gratitude or ingratitude is not the point. Such images of the rescued refugee cast the refugee as an inspiration, a model of determination, a "minor anecdote" in the story of Canadian exceptionalism. Like the long history of the media and the medical industry's parading of disabled children as poster children for medical and scientific fundraising, what critical disability studies scholar and activist Eli Clare calls the iconography of "hope in motion," the refugee poster child also embodies the nation's



**Figure I.3** Troeung family, in 1980, the “last” group of refugees to be sponsored from Cambodia as a part of the Canadian government’s Indochinese refugee resettlement program, being greeted by Canadian prime minister Pierre Trudeau who gestures with the Khmer *sampeah*. (Courtesy of the Troeung family. Photo credit unknown.)

investment in settler innocence and hope.<sup>14</sup> This is a settler subjectivity that deploys the image of one exalted racialized group (i.e., the refugee child) to sanitize and deflect from its systemic structure of ongoing settler-colonial violence. I have photos of myself as a baby staring into the camera as then Canadian prime minister Pierre Trudeau greets my family for a government-arranged photo op at Parliament Hill in Ottawa, just days after we arrived in Canada. I have watched the CBC news footage of this officious event in 1980: my mother and father bowing in gratitude with the Cambodian gesture of the *sampeah* to the prime minister, the embodiment of national magnificence.<sup>15</sup> In December 2019, I watched the CBC’s fortieth anniversary commemoration of this event on television again, the same image of me as a baby waving the Canadian flag flashing across the screen<sup>16</sup> (see Fig. I.3). In 2021, I wrote to the CBC asking them to take down the photos of me and my family published in their 2019 human interest story, “‘The wounds never go away’: Baby Y-Dang Named after Cambodian Refugee Camp Remembers Canadian Arrival.” I explained that I had supplied the CBC with some family photos and archival documents while in a state of mental distress, and

that the final article replicated a colonial practice of putting refugee images and information on public display in an exploitive way. The CBC journalist said she saw no evidence that I was experiencing a mental health crisis at the time of the interview. My request was denied. The commemoration lives on.

Heralded as a model for the world, the refugee program that brought my family to Canada incentivized ordinary Canadian citizens to become refugee sponsors by pledging matching government funds. The Special Indochinese Refugee Program was celebrated as such a success that, in 1986, the “people of Canada” were awarded the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) Nansen Refugee Award. Established in 1954 to honor “individuals, groups and organizations who go above and beyond the call of duty to protect refugees, displaced, and stateless people,” the 1986 Nansen Award remains the sole instance of the award being given to an *entire country*.<sup>17</sup> Even as the majority of the Canadian population polled in the early 1980s were against the government’s granting of asylum to Southeast Asian refugees, this period continues to be remembered by the liberal Canadian media as “an inspiring chapter in Canada’s immigration story, a testament to what citizen altruism can achieve when met with government goodwill.”<sup>18</sup> Feminist scholar of Canadian multiculturalism Sunera Thobani describes “the exalted subject” of whiteness as a figure included in the state to help delineate Canada’s “unique nationality.”<sup>19</sup> As Thobani explains, “Canadians routinely describe their citizenship, immigration, and refugee policies as the most humanitarian and compassionate in the world. These claims shape their sense of collective pride and national identity.”<sup>20</sup> This sentiment is evidenced in liberal establishment publications such as *The Walrus*, in which political commentator Simon Lewsen notes: “Canada prides itself on being a haven for the downtrodden.”<sup>21</sup> Within this national imaginary, the refugees themselves are remembered as little more than objects of charity, evacuated of personhood, to fit a familiar repertoire of Canadian exceptionalism.

From the images of Southeast Asian refugees in the 1970s to those of Syrian refugees after 2015, this refugee charity aesthetic has changed very little. In 2015, the media aired images of recently elected Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau welcoming a planeload of Syrian refugees to Canada. These refugees were being commemorated as the “first flight in a government program to resettle Syrians in Canada.”<sup>22</sup> In the video, Trudeau explains that the welcome ceremony is an attempt “to show the world how to open our hearts and welcome in people who are fleeing extraordinarily difficult situations. . . . They step off the plane as refugees, but they walk out of this terminal as permanent residents of Canada.”<sup>23</sup> Trudeau shakes hands with Syrian men and women as they disembark from the plane; he presents a young Syrian child with a



new winter coat; he reaches out to touch the arm of a Syrian infant held in her father's arms. For me, the gesture of welcome echoes across time and space. I am reminded of the CBC video footage of my family's arrival in 1980 and the welcome ceremony at Parliament Hill where Pierre Trudeau reaches out to pat my infant head.<sup>24</sup> There is an uncanny reflection between the Syrian girl and the Cambodian girl, the First and the Last, of the thousands of other charity "showpieces" in the nation's reiterating master narrative of benevolence. There is also a mirroring of Justin Trudeau and his father, the *good men* welcoming the *good refugees* to the *good refuge*. In the invisibilized background of both these images is the settler-colonial state's pattern of "quiet complicity" in the *longue durée* of war from Cambodia to Syria.<sup>25</sup> Finally, there are also echoes of war below the "welcome" videos in the online comments, which are full of vitriol and hate directed at both groups of refugees. Forty years apart, the Syrian girl and the Cambodian girl belong to the same image repertoire. Such repertoires have worked to shape a pervasive kind of silence for the refugee, delineating the boundaries of what can and cannot be said. What is permissible is the story of luck, gratitude, and goodness; what is impermissible is the recounting of the state's war making, abandonment, apathy, and racism. This is the violence of benevolence.

It is thus from this inescapable space of being made a refugee—by the infrastructures of permanent war, genocide, and forced displacement as well as by the repertoires of settler subjectivity—that the concept of refugee lifeworlds emerges. As an analytic, refugee lifeworlds builds on theories of biopolitics by Michel Foucault as well as Achille Mbembe's concepts of deathworlds and lifeworlds. As Foucault influentially argued, power disciplines the body and the mind in ways that are not merely destructive but also rehabilitative, corrective, or capacitating. Moreover, power-knowledge is never entirely monolithic: it domesticates subjectivity and renders the body docile just as it opens unforeseeable spaces of resistance. According to Foucault, biopower is characterized by an emphasis on the protection of life rather than destruction of life by a sovereign power. Focused on the regulation of bodies and the production of sexuality, biopower, Foucault argues, is "an explosion of numerous and diverse techniques for achieving the subjugations of bodies and the control of populations."<sup>26</sup> In his book *Necropolitics*, Mbembe argues, however, that notions of biopower inadequately account for modes of subjugation in our modern era that exceed the use of disciplinary technologies of the body to exercise sovereignty. Biopolitics only gives us half of the story of how warfare operates in the contemporary era. We need an understanding of how death, bare life, and the state of exception continue to saturate the zones of abandonment in vast swaths of the world. Mbembe thus asserts that "contemporary forms of

subjugating life to the power of death (necropolitics) are deeply reconfiguring the relations between resistance, sacrifice, and terror.”<sup>27</sup> Necropolitics and necropower involve the transformation of spaces into “death-worlds” in which vast populations become the “living dead.”<sup>28</sup> Deathworlds consist of entire spaces that are reduced to the temporalities of ensuing and impending death, wherein disposable populations are targeted for elimination with statistical perfection and minimal local resistance. If the deathworld is the zone of the living dead from which the refugee emerges (the ground zero upon which the refugee’s world is shattered and destroyed), then the lifeworld can perhaps be thought of as the space of regeneration wherein the refugee’s world might begin to be rebuilt. In *On the Postcolony*, Mbembe defines the “life world” as the dynamic zone of existence that arises from the fissures in the apparatus of colonial power. The lifeworld is where people “live their lives out and confront the very forms of their death.”<sup>29</sup> It is the space of everyday material life and death, an arena of existence marked by “its character of urgency, its distinctive mark, its eccentricities, its vocabularies, and its magic.”<sup>30</sup> In dialectical tension with the production of deathworlds, lifeworlds index the postcolony’s “languages of life.”<sup>31</sup> Capturing the material realities of “distress” and “terrible movements” of the postcolony, lifeworlds also asserts the postcolony’s unseen beauty and state of becoming.<sup>32</sup> Mbembe’s definition of lifeworlds reminds us of the need to find registers of meaning in the wake of colonialism, war, and genocide that can account for duress without flattening out states of existence that can attend to pleasure, creativity, and the heterogeneity of life in blocked passages without idealizing or romanticizing the site of the subaltern.

In this book, the lifeworld strives to reactivate and reanimate refugee ways of knowing and being that have been destroyed, depoliticized, and evacuated of meaning in the service of maintaining the liberal imperial status quo. Never wholly outside of, nor fully disciplined by, the infrastructures of legalistic, bureaucratic, and diagnostic power, refugee lifeworlds are the continually negotiated space of loss and survival, injury and joy, accommodation and refusal. As a concept, refugee lifeworlds explores and experiments with what the category of the refugee *can do* rather than what *it is*, especially when this term is brought to bear on, and critically juxtaposed with, other sites of knowledge: the Cold War in Cambodia, the Cambodian diaspora, critical disability studies, and transpacific studies.

### *From Trauma to Disability*

In an analytic sense, refugee lifeworlds intervenes at the limits of trauma theory. Trauma-based paradigms, such as theories of postmemory, haunting, and

intergenerational trauma, tend to reiterate a particular account of violence and disablement that locates the wounding “traumatic” moment in a discrete and distant past.<sup>33</sup> This is seen in trauma theory’s frequent recourse to tropes of haunting, spectrality, and the “return of the repressed.”<sup>34</sup> As feminist philosopher Veena Das writes, in trauma studies, it is “as if the processes that constitute the way everyday life is engaged in the present have little to say on how violence is produced or lived with.”<sup>35</sup> The end point of trauma theory, Lauren Berlant asserts, is too often “defining a group of individuals merely as afflicted with the same ailment.”<sup>36</sup> There also tends to be a universalization of trauma and an uncritical transposition of concepts and terms from one context to another. Such methods tend to obfuscate the particularities of specific conflicts and locations, lending priority to some genocides of the twentieth century as paradigmatic while “anecdoting” others as minor or peripheral. Moreover, theories of trauma can sometimes result in the imposition of a stigmatizing, deterministic lens on an entire community, wherein the community is seen as permanently and inescapably impaired and damaged, even at the molecular and genetic level.

Since the end of the Cold War, Cambodian people have been described and studied as one of the most “traumatized” populations in the world, with studies frequently emerging about the “appalling mental health crisis” said to be enveloping the Cambodian community.<sup>37</sup> Cambodian people are persistently described as having “psychological scars,” “psychological fallout,” and “major depression,” while Cambodia as a nation is characterized as a place defined by “decades of conflict,” “chronic poverty,” and “miserable conditions.”<sup>38</sup> Diagnostic rates of post-traumatic stress disorder have varied over time from as high as 86 percent of the Cambodian population in 1991 to roughly 40 percent of the population today.<sup>39</sup> The country’s “traumatic history” has been so determinant of the Cambodian narrative that “even those who did not live through genocide or civil war are often assumed to have inherited this suffering.”<sup>40</sup> In the United States in the early 1980s, Cambodians came to be associated with trauma and post-traumatic stress disorder to such an extent that the term “Depressed Cambodian Refugees” became a public cliché and synonymous with the diasporic population writ large.<sup>41</sup> In popular discourse, Cambodian people have been stigmatized as “cursed” with an irreparable and irreversible trauma that permeates their psyches and genetics.<sup>42</sup>

It cannot be denied that Cambodian people have lived through a history of trauma. The U.S. bombing of Cambodia left a legacy of body counts, maiming, and belated injury; the Cambodian Genocide that came afterward subjected Cambodian people to death and injury on a completely different order of magnitude. The Cambodian Genocide enveloped an *entire*

population of over six million people, killing a quarter of this population and debilitating the rest in physical and cognitive ways that are not yet fully understood. In other words, a quarter of Cambodia's population died during the genocide, and the remaining three-quarters of the population were physically and mentally debilitated. As critical disability studies scholar Jasbir Puar recounts about her fieldwork in four refugee camps in the West Bank, "There was not a single family or group of people among those we conversed with in the refugee camps that did not have close proximity to family and community with histories of disability."<sup>43</sup> In Cambodia and in the diaspora, I, likewise, have yet to meet a Cambodian family that was untouched by the violence of the war and genocide. As Cambodian Canadian graffiti artist FONKi Yav explains in the biopic documentary film *The Roots Remain*, "I always say, each family in Cambodia, and every person you meet here is directly linked to the genocide. It really wasn't that long ago."<sup>44</sup> FONKi's articulation of the rawness of the past emphasizes the visceral materiality of suffering that persists in Cambodian communities. It is necessary to affirm the trauma of Cambodian people as *real* without locking the community into an over-determined narrative of traumatic damage.

Today, Cambodian refugees continue to live with "substantial health disparities," including a disproportionate vulnerability to stroke and cardiovascular disease—two of the leading causes of death and disability in the United States.<sup>45</sup> These disparities have occurred not by happenstance but through exposure to interwoven systems of imperial and racial capitalism—U.S. bombings, the Khmer Rouge genocide, toxic and carcinogenic exposures, carceral humanitarianism, incarceration, urban and rural divestment, and deportation. In the words of Aihwa Ong, the author of the ethnographic study *Buddha Is Hiding*, Cambodian refugees who sought asylum in the United States moved "from a regime of power over death [in Cambodia] to a regime of power over life [in the United States]."<sup>46</sup> This "power over life" includes the preparation of refugee bodies for low-wage, precarious labor sectors such as factory line work, agricultural processing, farmwork, domestic labor, or sewing piece-work.<sup>47</sup> Many refugees, such as my own parents, worked all day on the factory lines and then, at night, turned to picking worms in the fields to make ends meet.<sup>48</sup> Unable to access childcare, they took me with them to the cemeteries where they picked worms at night, letting me sleep in the car until dawn. I offer this anecdote about our family's nightly worm picking work to suggest how the "overrepresentation" of Cambodian people with mental illness and disabilities highlights the structural and systemic divestment of this population, who, like my parents, could scarcely access a fraction of the psychological, disability, and health support services they actually needed as refugees

during those early years and resettlement. Rather, the persistent screams in their minds, the unhealed scars on their bodies, and the pain and sadness in their hearts not only went unaddressed but was intensified by new forms of physical and psychological incapacitation stemming from their new lives in Canada. This breaking down of the racialized body's capacity reflects Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition of racism—"the state-sanctioned or extralegal production and exploitation of group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death."<sup>49</sup> Undeniably, my mother and father lived with unaddressed trauma carried over from the war, but, more importantly, they lived with multiple forms of incapacity, debilitation, impairment, madness, and disability that dwell uneasily within the paradigm of "trauma studies" as it has developed with the Euro-American academy.

In this book, I seek to enact a shift in the way that we approach the question of trauma in the afterlife of the Cold War in Cambodia. This is a shift, I argue, from the language of trauma as an individual, knowable impairment to that of disability, understood as both a lived embodiment and a system of differential impairment of racialized and gendered bodies. Specifically, I turn in this book to the language, terminologies, and theoretical lexicons of *debility*, *cripistemology*, and *aphasia*, three key terms taken up in this book in ways that become clearer as this book unfolds. These terms offer necessary insights into the ways in which refugee bodies are marked by pain and suffering in ways that have yet to be adequately addressed in the existing scholarship. As critical disability studies scholars have argued, there is a need to attend to the production of disability (and, by extension, of refugee disablement) in the Global South, where 80 percent of the world's people with disabilities are located. Nirmala Erevelles, for instance, argues that the "violence of imperialism is instrumental not only in the creation of disability but also in the absence of public recognition of the impact of disability in the third world."<sup>50</sup> Helen Meekosha likewise proposes a "southern theory of disability" that "specifically incorporates the role of the global North in 'disabling' the global South."<sup>51</sup> The field of "southern disability," Jasbir Puar clarifies, is not simply an epistemological corrective of what is "left out" of the Eurocentric paradigm of disability studies: "It is, rather, a constitutive and capacitating absence" of this field.<sup>52</sup> That is, to conduct southern disability studies in places such as Cambodia, where paradigms of "refugee trauma" have generally displaced attention away from any kind of meaningful analyses of the geopolitics of disability, we must understand how Cambodia has been imbricated within the assemblages of what Puar, borrowing from Lauren Berlant, calls "slow death."<sup>53</sup> The concept of refugee lifeworlds move us into the realm of slow death in order to grasp not just how Cambodian refugee disability occurs



“within the time scale of the crisis” but how it “starts and stops, redoubles and leaps ahead” across time and space.<sup>54</sup>

### *Refugee Gain*

In turning to critical disability studies within the afterlife of the Cold War, I hope to avoid the common rhetorical conflation of disabled peoples “with the remnants of wartime trauma.”<sup>55</sup> As Natalia Duong suggests, it is important to see war and colonial violence as a primary cause for unfathomable amounts of death and debility, while also understanding how the consistent rhetorical conflation of war and disability can result in disabled bodies being represented as monstrous or horrific war remnants, rather than allowing “for disability to be valued.”<sup>56</sup> *Refugee Lifeworlds* attempts to avoid both the devaluing of disabled bodies as mere war remnants and the discursive occlusions of war and its afterlives as they have conditioned and continue to condition the lives of Cambodian refugees. I attempt this through the concept of “refugee gain.”

When I first began thinking about the concept of refugee lifeworlds, I was intrigued by the conversations about “disability gain” emerging in the field of critical disability studies. If disability gain was a concept being increasingly mobilized by the disability community, I wondered, might it also be possible to theorize a politically robust notion of “refugee gain”? Surely, I thought, it should be the goal of a refugee-scholar to develop a theory of refugee gain—to prove how refugees are positive and valuable assets to the economy and to society at large.

To be sure, “gain” is a loaded term. Gain conjures an association with the accumulation of wealth, money, and resources, but gain simply means an increase or an addition of something: for instance, the acquisition of a new worldview, political consciousness, or set of kinship relations. In the disability community, the word gain has been associated with the creativity and universal benefit of reorienting our societies toward disabled people’s needs. The term “deaf gain” was first coined by the performance artist Aaron Williamson in 2005 to describe how the accessibility accommodations developed to assist deaf people could also benefit society at large. Moreover, the politics of “deaf-gain” shifts the meanings of deafness away “from sensory lack to a form of sensory and cognitive diversity that offers vital contributions to human diversity.”<sup>57</sup> Picking up on this discourse emerging from the deaf community, disability studies scholar Rosemarie Garland-Thomson began using the term “disability gain” around 2016 to posit disability as a creative force rather than something to be corrected or eliminated. Not to be mistaken for meaning that the disabled body is somehow the product of a “fortunate” disabling accident,

the notion of disability gain stresses the need to divest from ableist logics of normalcy that posit disabled peoples as aberrant and, therefore, in need of correction or rehabilitation through, for instance, invasive technological interventions. In her *New York Times* op-ed essay titled “Becoming Disabled,” Garland-Thomson cites examples of disability gain such as: “learning to be disabled . . . by bonding with other young people new to disability”; “gaining blindness rather than losing sight”; and the collective gain of building accessibility, such as ramps and elevators, that originate from the history of ADA (Americans with Disabilities Act) legislation and disability activism.<sup>58</sup>

I remain compelled by the concept of disability gain, yet scholars have rightly pointed out the pitfalls of conceptualizing disability gain as an extension of liberal disability rights frameworks that situate the question of disability liberation as simply a matter of recognition, individual pride, and empowerment. This sentiment is expressed, for instance, in Garland-Thomson’s assertion that “disability is a resource, rather than a restriction.”<sup>59</sup> This limited understanding of disability gain tends to divert attention away from the structural causes of impairment to highlight instead the “creativity” or empowering aspects of disability. As Jasbir Puar points out, this perspective reinforces the “neoliberal transit of disability rights,” promoting a “highly privileged conversation about Western philosophical bioethics that remains uninterrogated in terms of distinctions between disability and debilitation.”<sup>60</sup> What Garland-Thomson’s work misses, Puar asserts, is “the politics of debilitation that render some populations as definitively unworthy of health and targeted for injury.”<sup>61</sup> While seeing disability as a condition of possibility is a laudable goal, this needs to be counterbalanced with a robust structural critique of how disability operates within the assemblage of racial, gendered, sexual, and settler-colonial violence. Instead of simply posing the question of how disability can be seen as a creative gain, we should be asking, in the words of Liat Ben-Moshe, “what can be gained from the presence of disability, or from disability justice or crip critiques of the carceral emanating from disability/mad movements?”<sup>62</sup> Put differently, what would an abolitionist notion of disability gain look like? Both Puar and Ben-Moshe move away from individual or identarian models of disability gain toward the potentiality of disability critique as a collective project of decolonial and disability liberation. As Puar asserts, a disability justice approach “is unequivocally antiwar, pro-labor, antiracist, prison abolitionist, and anti-imperialist. This approach is resolutely vigilant about critiquing U.S. imperialism both within the United States—as a settler colonial state—and internationally.”<sup>63</sup> In conjunction with these scholars, I posit here a theory that is less about (neoliberal models of) refugee gain and more about refugee and disability justice for all. It is vital that we

aim to dislodge the refugee from neoliberal identarian politics enmeshed within the assumptions and logics of global capitalism.

Both disabled peoples and refugees are also all too familiar with the binary of defect/cure that structures neoliberal discourses of refugee/disability gain. As Eli Clare writes, “Charity has long organized itself around the twin notions that disability is tragic and disabled people are pitiful.”<sup>64</sup> This logic, Clare argues, “frames disability yet again as damage located entirely within individual body-minds while disregarding the damage caused by ableism. It ignores the brilliant imperfection of our lives.”<sup>65</sup> The charity model also tends to remain invested in the exalted subject of the “disabled poster child” or what Clare calls the “supercrip” figure—the inspirational disabled person who has acquired success at all odds, *despite* their disability.<sup>66</sup> What is suppressed in the believe-it-or-not narrative of the poster child supercrip is the reckoning with ableism and with the conditions that make it so difficult for disabled peoples to access systemic liberation. As Robert McRuer argues, refugees are either “targeted in dominant discourses, alongside disabled people, as unwelcome welfare scroungers” and are “left out in the cold” by austerity measures and cuts to social services, or they are exalted by the state as exceptional symbols of inspiration.<sup>67</sup> Some refugees, as I have already discussed with reference to my own story, get singled out as “refugee poster children,” or “supercrip refugees,” if you will. As Gada Mahrouse has pointed out, the rhetorical figure of the “supercrip” figure in critical disability studies has the counterpart in refugee studies of a “super refugee” figure, whose “inspirational stories . . . similarly entrench a notion of responsibility at the level of the individual and not on society.”<sup>68</sup>

If we, as scholars, strive to abandon our commitments to any kind of neoliberal rationalities of refugee gain (that refugees are “good for the economy” or “models of resilience,” for example), then where does the refugee go from there? Ushered in by the foundational work of Yén Lê Espiritu, the field of critical refugee studies has sought to challenge these logics. Instead of the rooted citizen, Lê Espiritu argues, it is the refugee “that provides the *clue* to a new politics and model of international relations [emphasis mine].”<sup>69</sup> In his book *Unsettled: Cambodian Refugees in the New York City Hyperghetto*, Eric Tang argues that this clue resides in the refugee’s attuned sensitivity to the temporal reiterations of state power that sustain the refugee’s captivity—that is, in “the refugee’s knowledge that, with each crossing, resettlement, and displacement, an old and familiar form of power is being reinscribed.”<sup>70</sup> Vinh Nguyen describes this refugee knowledge as a mode of “refugeetude”—“a condition of possibility, a method of knowing and affecting the world.”<sup>71</sup> The refugee’s embodiment of an emergent world is linked to her possession of a

critical consciousness that has the potential to disrupt the taken-for-granted order of power.

The refugee intimates *a world to come*—a world increasingly straining under the pressures of empire, global capitalism, and climate insecurity. Like Hannah Arendt's assertion of the epistemic power of the Jewish refugee as a "conscious pariah,"<sup>72</sup> my parents have always affirmed the view that Cambodian people's experience of surviving Pol Pot time represents knowledge of *value*—for the society at large but especially for our own community. They believed that this knowledge could fortify us (in the second generation and beyond) for the inevitably difficult future to come. As Cambodian American writer Anthony Veasna So explains, his father's favorite joke was about how the Khmer Rouge years were good preparation to be a future contestant on *Survivor*.<sup>73</sup> As So's literary fiction makes clear, the ability to balance sorrow and humor in relating to the traumatic past is part of what So *gained*, not what he had to overcome, as an inheritance from his Cambodian refugee parents. Vietnamese American writer Thi Bui, in her graphic memoir *The Best We Could Do*, describes this inherited survivalist mentality as a "refugee reflex"—an acute sensitivity to the signs of impending threat, a resourcefulness, and an innate adaptability in the face of hardship.<sup>74</sup> As a subject made and remade by this new world of increasing global precarity, the refugee can embody vital knowledges and resources that will usher in paradigms of planetary humanity. Put differently, the refugee opens up ways of knowing futurity—beneficial knowledge for how we might coexist and care for each other through the protracted temporality of the *long collapse*. In this view, refugees are no longer charity cases and objects of pity. With accelerating waves of climate refugees arriving at the borders, it is the receiving nations who might be characterized as the "lucky" recipients of the knowledge, skills, and flexibility the refugee carries.

That the refugee has the potential to be both a presage of future insecurity and an index of the costs of wars past was an idea articulated by Michel Foucault in 1979, when he wrote that Cambodia's tragedy would also serve as "a foreshadowing of the 21st century's great migration" if the world continued to remain apathetic.<sup>75</sup> As new coordinates of empire have emerged around the world as laboratories of the "New Cold War,"<sup>76</sup> generating newer and newer waves of refugee displacements, the twenty-first century has seen Foucault's predictions come to pass. Driven by interlocking systems of colonialism, war, militarism, climate change, and racial capitalism, the "crisis" of refugee displacement is indicative of a state of permanent wartime that has marked the post-Cold War era. As Ai Weiwei aptly puts it, the "refugee crisis isn't about refugees. It's about us."<sup>77</sup> Instead of erecting more walls and borders to keep

refugees out, Ai asserts, “we should look at what is causing people to become refugees and work to solve those conditions.”<sup>78</sup> To do so will require that global state powers confront “how they are using political and economic ideology—enforced by overwhelming military power—to disrupt entire societies.”<sup>79</sup> At the present moment, there are approximately 70.8 million officially recognized “displaced subjects” worldwide.<sup>80</sup> A 2020 report by the “Costs of War” project at Brown University “conservatively estimates that at least 37 million people have fled their homes in the eight most violent wars the U.S. military has launched or participated in since 2001.”<sup>81</sup> According to David Vine, a primary researcher of this study, this human displacement will only continue to accelerate so long as we have “the continuation of endless, infinite war.”<sup>82</sup> As the costs of war are borne most heavily by refugees, how might the refugee’s knowledge help steer us toward the horizon of war’s abolition? Refugee lifeworlds is a lens of critique, a making palpable of politics through embodied ways of knowing and sensing that arise from refugee and disability experience.

To argue, however, that the refugee represents a clue to modern futurity still poses its own conceptual problems as it demands that the refugee be made useful for a broader political agenda. I am not saying that refugees are valuable only because of the resourcefulness they embody. Such a claim instrumentalizes the refugee, like the story of Cambodia, “as epiphenomena” for the primary purpose of mounting a critique of power.<sup>83</sup> Notwithstanding the urgency of such critiques, it is important to underscore that the concept of refugee lifeworlds does not hinge on notions of what the refugee can do for others, or how the refugee can be an example of freedom for others. It asserts the dignity and humanity of the refugee on her own terms.

### *An Abolitionist Refugee Lens*

The term “refugee lifeworlds” signals my desire to bring the fields of critical refugee studies and critical disability studies into closer dialogue, while being mindful of the dangers of an overinvestment in what Hortense Spillers has called “the studies protocol” that dictates the contemporary academic landscape.<sup>84</sup> The zones of intersection between refugee life and disability will always exceed the ossified protocols of institutionalized academic practice, yet I remain committed to what might emerge by routing this analysis through the Cambodian refugee archive. Informed by feminist, crip, queer, transpacific, Indigenous, Black, and critical refugee methods, *Refugee Lifeworlds* asserts the need to envision an intersectional, abolitionist politics of disability and refugee justice that, in Liat Ben-Moshe’s words, “is related to one’s positional-

ity in relation to power and not identification.”<sup>85</sup> Here, we can learn from crip of color critique, Ben-Moshe writes, that urges us “to understand vast social problems through an intersectional lens that has a broader analysis of what we come to call freedom and what liberation might be, not just for the inclusion of some but for the connected liberation of us all.”<sup>86</sup> Abolition, Ben-Moshe writes, “is not merely about closures of prisons or institutions; it is a revolutionary framework that transforms the way we analyze and understand the forces that shape our histories and everyday lives.”<sup>87</sup> Abolition is a political framework for eliminating slavery, war, carceral systems, and white supremacy, as well as an epistemology that challenges dominant ways of thinking and the status quo. Abolitionist knowledge reconceptualizes notions like crime and innocence; disability, madness, and rehabilitation; ideas of punishment; notions of freedom and equality; and concepts of danger and protection. Ben-Moshe’s discussion of abolition specifically relates to what she calls “*race-ability*,” a theory that sutures the study of race and disability, racism and ableism, in ways that go beyond neoliberal and multicultural paradigms of minoritized inclusion. According to Ben-Moshe, *race-ability* is defined as “the ways race and disability, and racism, sanism, and ableism as intersecting oppressions, are mutually constitutive and cannot be separated, in their genealogy (eugenics, for example), current iterations of resistance (in the form of disability justice, for example), or oppression (incarceration and police killing, for example).”<sup>88</sup>

An abolitionist refugee lens of critique must seek to account for the depoliticized incorporation and recruitment of the refugee figure into the systems of liberal empire and racial capitalism. To be sure, there is nothing inherently revolutionary about the refugee, or any marginalized identity, as Gayatri Spivak’s work on the subaltern subject has long reminded us.<sup>89</sup> The refugee can easily be enlisted to perform the role of the grateful citizen to help perpetuate the empire’s projects of war making at home and abroad. As Mimi Thi Nguyen writes, the “refugee patriot” plays an important role in converting the U.S. imperial past into a military rationale for perpetual war.<sup>90</sup> Weaponized as a tool of liberal empire, this refugee patriot helps sustain the U.S. state’s myths of a “just war” alongside the demands for the refugee’s interminable debt for the gift of freedom.<sup>91</sup>

The refugee’s participation in the reproduction of empire can be seen, for instance, in the example of Vietnamese American refugee Nguyet Anh Duong, colloquially known as “the Bomb Lady.” Duong has been described as “one of the most important weapons-developers of the modern era.”<sup>92</sup> An engineer commissioned by the Pentagon in the aftermath of 9/11, Duong created the first U.S. thermobaric bomb credited with helping “win” the war in Afghanistan. As Achille Mbembe explains, thermobaric bombs are among the



cruellest forms of technological warfare in the twenty-first century, “release[ing] walls of fire, absorbing all the oxygen from surrounding spaces, . . . [and] asphyxiating nearly everything that breathes.”<sup>93</sup> Duong traces her inspiration for this weapon back to her feelings of indebtedness to “the soldiers and to Americans” who helped her escape from Vietnam.<sup>94</sup> As a refugee-turned-bomb-lady, Duong exemplifies the far reaches of the war machine’s ability to incorporate citizens—refugees and nonrefugees alike—into the apparatus of the U.S. forever war.

In the case of Cambodia, the country’s conflation with the brutality of Communism helps facilitate a specific narrative of U.S. exceptionalism that invokes Cambodia as a horrifying specter of what can happen when America “abandons” its non-Communist allies abroad. A 2019 television ad from New Faces GOP resurrected this trope again recently.<sup>95</sup> Featuring a Cambodian American woman named Elizabeth Heng, the ad begins with an image of Congresswoman Alexandria Ocasio Cortez’s face superimposed with graphic images of the skeletal remains of victims of the Cambodian Genocide. As the camera lingers on these iconic images of the “Killing Fields,” Heng questions whether Cortez “knows the horror of socialism,” implicitly comparing her policies to those of Pol Pot’s regime.<sup>96</sup> The video’s graphic sensationalism and mobilization of Heng as an authentic Cambodian voice prompted an outcry from many Cambodian Americans who protested the blatant weaponization of the community’s history of suffering. Making no mention of the U.S. war crimes that precipitated the Cambodian Genocide, the political advertisement instantiates a narrative of rescue in which Cambodian refugees are deemed “lucky” recipients of a U.S. liberal humanitarianism that defines itself against a monstrous Khmer Rouge Communism. The example makes visible how easily the refugee figure can be incorporated into U.S. imperial statecraft and mobilized not simply to misremember past war but also to power more cycles of collateral damage.

An abolitionist refugee lens must also contend with the uneasy slippage between the “unsettled” refugee subject and the “refugee as settler,” holding the formations of imperial displacement and settler colonialism in productive tension as coconstitutive tactics of white supremacy. There is a need, Dean Itsuji Saranillio has argued, to reckon with “multicultural forms of settler colonialism” in which migrants and refugees reinforce the hierarchies of the white settler-colonial state.<sup>97</sup> Laura Madokoro frames this issue as a matter of “refugee settlerhood,” asking “when and how might one start thinking of migrants as settlers? At what cost? And at what gains?”<sup>98</sup> Any consideration of the refugee’s agency as a political figure, Madokoro writes, “must equally attend to the manner in which the movement of migrants, including refu-

gees, has facilitated the production of norms and narratives that contribute to the ongoing dispossession of Indigenous peoples.”<sup>99</sup> We need to be careful, however, not to flatten out the nuances of this racial reckoning. As Iyko Day argues, our interracial coalitional politics might be better served by a model of racial triangulation wherein we see the “alien” (Black people in the system of chattel slavery and Asian people in that of indentured labor) as triangulated with and against Indigenous peoples to perpetuate the interests of the white settler-colonial state. If we cast our analytics on colonialism’s methods of “divide and conquer” rather than on fixed hierarchies of oppression, then we productively resist subsuming all migrants and refugees into “a generalized settler position.”<sup>100</sup> To do otherwise, Day argues, risks constraining “our ability to understand how their racialized vulnerability and disposability supports a settler colonial project.”<sup>101</sup> Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi’s work attends specifically to the place of the refugee within settler-colonial contexts, theorizing what she calls “the refugee settler condition,” “the vexed positionality of refugee subjects whose citizenship in a settler colonial state is predicated upon the unjust dispossession of an Indigenous population.”<sup>102</sup> The work of these theorists emphasizes the importance of refugee lifeworlds as a theory that does not simply condemn all refugees as settlers nor does it absolve them of their participation in settler colonialism and other structures of oppression.

By definition, to be “settled” is to find a condition of stability or security of some sort. Refugees displaced across national borders, such as Cambodian refugees, are settlers in the abstract sense, but they are also often profoundly “unsettled” in other ways. As Eric Tang writes, in the aftermath of the Cold War, Cambodian American refugees were better described as “recaptured” than “re-settled” upon arrival in the United States. Warehoused in urban “hyperghetto” infrastructures and consigned to low-wage, precarious labor, Cambodian American refugees found themselves confronting perpetual economic insecurity, criminalization, and fear of deportation.<sup>103</sup> Their unsettled refugee passage—from the Cambodian war zone, to refugee camp, to U.S. hyperghetto, to U.S. prison, to Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) detention, and then “back” to Cambodia as deported “illegal aliens”—complicates the view that the refugee has escaped the circuits of imperial captivity upon arrival in the state of asylum. Like Tang, who rejects the assimilationist teleologies of refugee “resettlement that require one to first acknowledge that a threshold has been crossed, that the displaced have entered entirely new conditions and matrices of power,”<sup>104</sup> I question any universalizing discourses predicated on the refugee’s assumed crossing into an uncomplicated settler identity.<sup>105</sup>

Moreover, *Refugee Lifeworlds* strives to illuminate how many refugees might identify as Indigenous peoples themselves. In Cambodia, Indigenous

peoples are variously called ethnic minorities, hill tribes, highlanders, highland people, Indigenous people, Khmer Leu, or *Choncheat*. There are an estimated twenty-four different Indigenous groups spread across Cambodia's fifteen provinces, with the Kuy, Mnong, Stieng, Brao, Tampuan, Pear, Jorai, Rade, and Bunong being among the largest communities.<sup>106</sup> Known as the caretakers of Cambodia's sacred forests, waters, mountains, and land, the cosmologies of these communities affirm a collective obligation of all humankind to care for the natural world. In particular, the Kuy and Tampuan people are considered by the Khmer to be the aboriginal inhabitants of the land. Collectively, these peoples assert the long presence of indigeneity on the territorial land of Cambodia, a nation on the Pacific Rim, as well as on its numerous coastal islands, all situated in the Gulf of Thailand, itself part of the larger Pacific Ocean.

As in other colonial endeavors throughout history, during the Cold War in Cambodia, Cambodian Indigenous groups were recruited to fight on different sides of the war. The archives of historian Michael Vickery contain extensive photographic collections of these groups from the northeastern Cambodian province of Ratanakiri. Vickery's 1961 collection of the army in Lomphat community, Ratanakiri, for example, shows images of Indigenous men donning the military uniforms of the Royal Khmer Armed Forces.<sup>107</sup> Cambodian social anthropologist Krisna Uk has also studied the history of Indigenous soldiering in her book *Salvage*, an in-depth ethnography of the Jorai (ជ្រៃ) in Cambodia's northeastern Ratanakiri Province. In the 1970s, some Jorai were enlisted to work with the U.S. Special Forces during the Cold War. After years of living under the U.S. bombardments, other Jorai were recruited by the Khmer Rouge, used as bodyguards for Pol Pot, who felt that the Jorai's "knowledge of the jungle, combined with their interest in revolutionary ideas and their fighting skills, made them the most dependable fighters."<sup>108</sup> Uk writes that the Jorai Indigenous peoples' practice of salvaging the explosive remnants of the U.S. bombing were an "integral part of their livelihood strategy"—a "harvesting of metal in return for financial gain."<sup>109</sup> For the Jorai, Uk argues, salvaging is not merely a transactional activity but "lies at the heart of the cultural resilience of the people," enabling the Jorai "to transform fragments of weapons and painful shards of memory into refashioned and resymbolized objects used in their rituals and day-to-day life."<sup>110</sup> After the war, some Jorai were resettled in the United States and Canada as simply "Cambodian refugees," their Indigenous heritages generally unacknowledged or erased. These Indigenous people turned "Indigenous soldiers" turned "Indigenous refugees" turned "Indigenous refugee settlers" embody multiple lines of contradictory affiliations. On the one hand, they have been entangled within the same militarized currents of U.S. transpa-

cific empire that have disproportionately enlisted Indigenous peoples across the Pacific into the work of U.S. soldiering and war making. On the other hand, their plight is linked to the vast global archipelago of settler-colonial genocide, segregation, land expropriation, racism, criminalization, and cultural and linguistic erosion—as well as Indigenous peoples’ ongoing struggles against these systems worldwide.

My own family history has made me attuned to the complicated layering of refugee, Indigenous, and settler identity in many Cambodian families. As a young man, my father (who was a part of the Teochew Chinese ethnic minority in Cambodia) lived for two years with the Kuy Indigenous people in a small village fifty kilometers outside of the city of Kampong Thom known as Phumi O Pou (ភូមិ អូរពោធិ៍). At the time, in the late 1960s, the Chinese Cambodian community and the Kuy worked together in the business of trading and selling rice wine. My father describes his relationship with the Kuy with great fondness. From the Kuy, my father learned how to survive in the wild: how to hunt, fish, work, and live off everything the jungle and forest could provide. He learned how to make medicinal remedies from resin and to forage for food. Without this knowledge, my father often says, he may not have survived the harsh conditions of Pol Pot time, when Cambodian people were thrust into the wild and forced to fend for themselves. In one of his memories of Pol Pot time, my father remembers how a Kuy person helped save his life: Recognizing my father from the “old days,” the Kuy helped conceal my father’s identity from the Khmer Rouge cadres in the village. The Kuy gave my father two traditional Kuy torches, made of dry preal leaves and rubber, to help him navigate through the dark forest. The Kuy bowed his hands in the gesture of the *sampeah* and said the torches were a gift to repay a debt from the past, when my father had been in good relations with the Kuy people. These anecdotes from my father’s memories illuminate the messiness of the multiple contradictions that come to the fore when the lens of refugee seeking, disability, and indigeneity are all brought to bear on the same scene.

## The Cambodian Refugee Archive

Responsive to the calls for cultivating methods that are wayward, undisciplined, transpacific, and crip,<sup>111</sup> *Refugee Lifeworlds* assembles an archive of Cambodian writing that enacts the politics of refusal. This is a refusal of imperial, carceral, and white supremacist state violence that has rendered refugee lives disposable and ungrievable—as the collateral damage of imperial wars and global racial capitalism. This refusal is also what critical disability studies scholars have termed a “crip willfulness”—a “refusal to act in accordance

with the system of compulsory able-bodiedness.”<sup>112</sup> In naming a “crip Cambodian refugee archive,” I bring together a lens of critical disability studies and critical refugee studies as I follow the work of scholars such as Ma Vang, in her book *History on the Run*, who imagines a Hmong refugee archive that “reckons with the question of how to engage with memory, the politics of our lack of knowledge about history, and the production of such knowledge.”<sup>113</sup> Like Vang’s study, which “is neither an empirical study of who Hmong are” nor a positivist recovery of “refugee secrets,”<sup>114</sup> *Refugee Lifeworlds* posits a Cambodian refugee archive that hinges on the unknowable and the uncertain, which is by nature incomplete, partial, and fragmentary.

### *Transpacific Currents*

The Cambodian refugee archive registers the debilitating currents of Cold War transpacific militarism that are the currents of U.S. aerial war, proxy war, occupation, injury, maiming, and killing in Cambodia. As Jasbir Puar writes, “Capitalism, war, forced migration, settler colonial occupation, and . . . U.S. capitalist imperialism are the generators of much of the world’s disability.”<sup>115</sup> Far from being the routes through which the United States brought “freedom” and “liberation” to Southeast Asia during the Cold War, the “transpacific” represents in many ways the North-South currents of militarized intervention through which the endemic debilitation of Cambodia and the Cambodian diaspora has been produced and reproduced from the Cold War onward.

Invoked as a noun, a critical method, or an adjective, the term “transpacific” references movement back and forth, across and within the Pacific Ocean. The field of transpacific studies leans frequently on the image of ceaseless, intersecting ocean currents as its central structuring metaphor. Whereas the diasporic paradigm in Asian American studies during the 1990s and 2000s tended to focus on the ongoing connections Asian Americans maintained with the ancestral homeland, the transpacific paradigm emphasizes, according to Janet Hoskins and Viet Thanh Nguyen, the “traffic in peoples, cultures, capital, and ideas between ‘America’ and ‘Asia,’ as well as across the troubled ocean that lends its name to this model.”<sup>116</sup> A response to triumphalist discourse surrounding the economic success of Asia Pacific and Pacific Rim nations in the 1980s, transpacific studies seeks to challenge the largely economic interpretation of the fantasy of the “Pacific Century” favored by the U.S.-led global capitalism. The transpacific thus names a contact zone of “critical engagement with and evaluation of such development and fantasy.”<sup>117</sup> As a heuristic of multidirectional traffic, flows, and currents, YẾN LÊ ESPRITU, Lisa Lowe, and Lisa Yoneyama argue that the concept of “transpacific entangle-

ments” makes visible how “U.S. empire and militarism in Asia and the Pacific Islands have been critical, yet underrecognized, parts of the genealogy of the contemporary condition of U.S. neoliberalism.”<sup>118</sup> Imperial discourses, they argue, have worked “to naturalize U.S. presence and possession in Asia and the Pacific Islands through the imperatives of national security and wartime necessity, to racialize the peoples it captures, occupies, kills, and governs.”<sup>119</sup> The frequent representations of Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, and North Korea as inert fixtures of communist otherness often have the effect of forgetting America’s role in waging war and destabilizing these nations in the first place.

As the field of transpacific studies has developed, scholars have pointed out the need to attend to several currently existing epistemological limitations of the field—to recognize that there are multiple Pacifics at play across the vast space of the ocean. The first critique is that transpacific studies has tended to exclude the Indigenous societies and ecological environments present in the actual space of the Pacific Ocean. Scholars of Oceania studies Tiara R. Na’puti and Michael Lujan Bevacqua argue that this privileging of the periphery treats the Pacific Ocean as “a place meant to be traversed by imperial and world powers, rather than a site from which we can understand the structure of colonial power.”<sup>120</sup> As Aimee Bahng and Erin Suzuki write, “We need to resist this ‘flyover’ model and reevaluate the term ‘transpacific’ in relation to Pacific studies, Indigenous studies, and Oceanic studies.”<sup>121</sup> Another critique involves the call to attend to what Tina Chen calls the “‘epistemic asymmetry’ of the transpacific [that] presents both a challenge and a promise.”<sup>122</sup> For Chen, the multiple transpacific “turns” the field has undergone in the past decade—toward the study of militarized currents, ecological lifeworlds, and Indigenous world making—productively resists the field’s reification of a “single preponderant logic.”<sup>123</sup> Finally, scholars have argued that there is a need to focus our critical energies on the more “minor nodes” of the Pacific Ocean and the Pacific Rim. As Christine Kim and Helen Leung write, the concept of the “minor transpacific” considers how “imperial desires and practices have shaped minor players such as Canada, Australia, or Singapore.”<sup>124</sup> These “minor empires” can be thought of as “privileged, but not entirely dominant, members of the global public.”<sup>125</sup> The minor transpacific directs us away from national and imperial sites that have historically dominated the circuits of knowledge production and helps us foreground new perspectives and contexts.<sup>126</sup> As these scholars make clear, it is possible and even desirable to attend to the spaces of the actual Pacific and transpacific at the same time. The two do not need to be mutually exclusive, just as attention to the minor nodes and currents need not subtract from a focus on the major ones.



More so than with earlier waves of Cambodian writing, the Cambodian refugee archive that I examine in this book does not merely celebrate movement across the Pacific Ocean: It engages in the work of theorizing what Lisa Yoneyama terms a “decolonial genealogy of the transpacific.”<sup>127</sup> For Cambodian refugees forcibly displaced by the Cold War military interventions of the global superpowers, the transpacific has not been the abstract place of fluid transit, flexibility, or liminality celebrated by global capitalism. Rather, the “Cambodian transpacific” is a current formed in and through the imperial formation of the Cold War. As such, it represents a space of U.S. aerial bombardment, proxy war, debt imperialism, enforced refugee crossing, and ongoing Cambodian American refugee deportation. The “Cambodian minor transpacific” traces lesser-known or unexpected circuits between Cambodia and the transpacific Cold War formation, such as the militarized currents of Black soldiering in Cambodia, linkages between Canada and Cambodia, U.S. carceral circuits of Cambodian American deportation across the Pacific, and intra-Asian circulations between Cambodia and Asian nations such as Vietnam, Thailand, Japan, and China. Attention to these minor flows helps us interrupt U.S.-centric configurations of transpacific studies and spotlights Cambodia’s embeddedness within a global web of relations and entanglements.

The transpacific Cambodian refugee archive also disembarks from the familiar shores of the testimonial autobiographical form. As Teri Shaffer Yamada has discussed, the first “phase”<sup>128</sup> of Cambodian writing in the diaspora (exemplified by the works of authors such as Haing S. Ngor, Pin Yathay, Someth May, Loung Ung, and Chanrithy Him) consistently employed the autobiographical testimonial form and remained “narrowly framed around the tragic 1975–79 experience of the Pol Pot era in Cambodia.”<sup>129</sup> This body of writing, discussed in depth by scholars such as Shaffer Yamada and Cathy J. Schlund-Vials, reflected the necessity of combating a contested history in Cambodia through the use of nonfiction.

Like many refugees today, the first Cambodian refugees who managed to escape to the border of Thailand to tell their stories were not believed. They were accused of fabricating or exaggerating their accounts.<sup>130</sup> Given the failure of justice in Cambodia characterized by the belated arrival of the Extraordinary Chambers in the Courts of Cambodia, Cambodian American autobiographies throughout the 1990s were propelled by “the need for evidence, to substantiate Khmer Rouge atrocities.”<sup>131</sup> The ongoing absence of justice and reconciliation for Cambodians, Yamada argues, “provides one explanation for why there has been more life writing by or about Cambodians than by or about any other Asian ethnic cohort in the United States during

the past several decades.”<sup>132</sup> The proliferation of Cambodian life narratives in the Cold War and post–Cold War era cannot be disentangled from the context of failed accountability, widespread historical silence about the Khmer Rouge era, and a deep sense of unreconciled wounds among survivors.

The prevalence of the testimonial writing, “an authentic narrative, told by a witness who is moved to narrate by the urgency of a situation,”<sup>133</sup> reflected the Cold War context conditioning the emergence of this writing. In the *testimonio* form, “the witness portrays his or her own experience as an agent (rather than a representative) of collective memory and identity. Truth is summoned in the cause of denouncing a present situation of exploitation and oppression or in exorcising and setting aright official history.”<sup>134</sup> Testimony, as Naomi Paik writes, functions as “a first-person narrative told from the perspective of the witness who offers it. But just as crucial, testimony is authentic. It conveys its narrative as true, as emerging from the actual lived experiences of the witness.”<sup>135</sup> Beyond a simple recounting of the past, testimony constitutes a “part of a strategy of survival and self-constitution, and it attempts to seize the listener, to insist that we engage.”<sup>136</sup> For Cambodian refugees, testimony is about recounting one’s firsthand experience of war, genocide, displacement, resettlement, and survival; it is also about reclaiming compromised selfhood and about making appeals to asylum nations to open their borders.

Though useful for its time, the first phase of Cambodian cultural production tended to be limited by the testimonial form, straining as it did to reconstruct *the way things really happened* during the Cambodian Genocide. These texts rendered the meaning of the Cold War in Cambodia exclusively as a story of holocaust survival, often drawing on the form and style of popular Jewish Holocaust testimonials such as Anne Frank’s *The Diary of a Young Girl* and Elie Wiesel’s *Night* trilogy.<sup>137</sup> Cambodian memoirs of the first phase tended to eclipse any kind of sustained thematic or aesthetic exploration of other wartime experiences that preceded or followed the Cambodian Genocide. As such, they tended to reinforce, whether advertently or inadvertently, the bipolar Cold War frame of containment that required hot war sites in Asia to be viewed as threatening sites of potential Communist expansion that needed to be contained at all costs.<sup>138</sup> Since Cambodia was already viewed by many in America as the ultimate realization of the failure of U.S. Cold War containment, Cambodian testimonial memoirs tended to be easily folded into the “red scare” discourse of the era in which the Khmer Rouge became the embodiment of what the United States was trying to liberate Asia from rather than what the United States had helped create. As Cambodian artist Vandy Rattana, creator of the “Bomb Ponds” photography series, has asserted, it is not enough to just collect testimonies: “This type of artistic practice

lacks depth, and most Cambodians don't seek the cause of the genocide."<sup>139</sup> It is this seeking of the deeper causes of the Cambodian Cold War formation that distinguishes the transpacific archive.

### *Kapok Trees and Aphasia*

Saturated by tropes of pain, suffering, loss, illness, speechlessness, silence, muteness, deafness, blindness, prosthesis, and many other modalities of impairment, the Cambodian refugee archive is also an archive of disability. In French Cambodian artist Tian Veasna's graphic novel *Year of the Rabbit*, for instance, a Cambodian elder warns his son that if he wants "to survive under the new regime," he would do well to remember the "old saying": "you need to plant kapok and palm trees around your house" (see Fig. I.4).<sup>140</sup> This piece of survival advice given from a Cambodian elder to his son comes after the sharing of anecdotal information about the Khmer Rouge regime's targeted persecution of "former bureaucrats or intellectuals." One panel depicts this rumored slaughter in the illustration of a refugee boat on the Tonle Sap River under attack by the Khmer Rouge: From a distance, we see the boat surrounded by a bright red patch and the abstract bodies of people being thrown overboard. The next panel zooms in on the image of Khmer Rouge soldiers cleaning the "pools of blood on the deck" of the boat. This four-panel sequence of genocidal violence, debilitating witnessing, and refugee rumor sharing is then interrupted—temporally, visually, and aesthetically—by a panel depicting the Cambodian elder's warning to the younger generation that "you have to be careful." This warning not only interrupts the narration of violence but serves as the frame (indicated by the right-facing positioning of the Cambodian elder) for the very next panel and following two pages in which the kapok tree proverb is introduced and explained. After a panoramic panel depicting a field of kapok and palm trees, we see the text of the proverb, and, below it, a traditional Cambodian home (inhabited by a single person) nestled between a towering kapok tree on one side and an even taller palm tree on the other side. The two trees, in their strength and silence, protect the Khmer person and home. It is also significant that the kapok tree casts a shadow that envelops the house, a pool of shade that mirrors but also contrasts the pool of blood from the massacre scene on the opposite page. The *act of planting the kapok tree* is emphasized as the undertaking and the state of being that will help Khmer people navigate persecution by the Khmer Rouge.

The scene in Veasna's graphic novel unfolds as a foreshadowing of the dark times to come, as a moment of intergenerational knowledge transmission, and as a visual inscription of Cambodian people's will to survive, what



Figure I.4a Frames from the graphic novel *Year of the Rabbit*, 2019, by Tian Veasna, pp. 86–87, illustrate the Khmer kapok tree proverb, “plant a kapok tree,” which means “see nothing, hear nothing, say nothing.” (Courtesy of Tian Veasna.)





Figure I.4b



Figure I.4c



some Cambodians have termed “emotional resistance.”<sup>141</sup> It is what my mother, in our home while I was growing up, called *kamleang chet* (strength of the heart). Throughout the remainder of *Year of the Rabbit*’s sprawling 368 pages, the kapok tree recurs in frame after frame, a discreet element of the setting infused with rich symbolism: It is a witness and a holder of memory, it is an index of Cambodian people’s transformed relationship to language under duress, and it expresses a Khmer epistemology of survival, resilience, and regeneration. As the final landscape panel in the “kapok sequence” of Veasna’s graphic novel suggests, planting the kapok tree also means making oneself as small, as silent, and as invisible as possible. In the image, we see two small boats that have left the coast, barely visible as objects against the vast expanse of the Tonle Sap River. Enlarged and almost blending in with the clouds, the proverb resonates and resounds across the skies, loud enough for all Cambodians to hear: “See nothing, hear nothing, say nothing.”

In Khmer, the word *kor* means both “kapok” and “mute.” It is said that when the wind blows in Cambodia, the leaves of *doeum-kor* make no sound; therefore, the kapok tree is like a person who is mute, or, rather, a person who is mute is like the ancient kapok tree. During the Khmer Rouge years, Cambodian people recited the proverb to each other as a word of wisdom from one Cambodian person to another about how to survive the genocide. To plant a kapok tree (*dam-doeum-kor*), then, exists as a form of refugee knowledge, as an idiom of disability, and as a way of knowing, being, and surviving in a system of genocidal violence and its afterlife.

The kapok tree is a source of livelihood and meaning for Cambodian people: Its silky fibers are used for textile production and cushion stuffing; its plants and seedpods are eaten as snacks, and its bark can be used medicinally to treat illnesses (see Fig. I.5). When I was growing up, my father often told me about the kapok tree. As a child, he loved the dry season in Cambodia when the kapok tree pods would ripen, turning from bright green to brown and growing to the size of corn husks. He remembers the large piles of harvested brown pods at his father’s trading business in Kampong Thom, where workers removed the cotton fibers from these pods (see Fig. I.6). To him, the tree was like magic, its fluffy white cotton the material of all the pillows and cushions that lined his household. The kapok tree grew everywhere, belonged to no one, and provided for everyone.

Many years later, after the Khmer Rouge came to power, the kapok tree represented something very different. When my father was away on assignment with a men’s work brigade, he came across a field of these trees one day. He knew that it was now forbidden by Angkar for Cambodians to forage for food or plant vegetables of their own. All the resources of the land that



**Figure I.5** A kapok tree swaying in a field in the countryside of Cambodia. (Photo by Sothy An, via Shutterstock.)



**Figure I.6** Harvested kapok tree fibers, Kampong Cham Province, August 28, 2016. (Screen capture from *Kapok in Cambodia* by Leanghort Sok.)

had provided for Cambodian people for centuries—the trees, the water, the plants—were now the sole property of the state. People were given only two bowls of rice gruel each day. “Stealing” food was punishable by death. And so, many people starved, watched their loved ones starve, even as the natural

abundance of the land flourished all around them. On this day, in front of the kapok tree, my father weighed the risks and benefits of defying the regime to feed himself and his family, as he would do hundreds of times over the course of the next four years. Taking the risk, he picked some pods from the tree, cracked them open and savored their delicious black seeds under the cool shade of the quiet branches. For this brief moment, the kapok tree quelled his hunger and reminded him of the old days, the happy times, before the war.

During the Cambodian Genocide, knowing that their words could be overheard by the Khmer Rouge and used as evidence of treason, my father, like most Cambodians, refrained from speaking. In some cases, they witnessed scenes of cruelty and violence that they could not encapsulate in words. Cambodian people, like my parents, possessed an acute awareness of when to speak or not to speak, of whom to trust and not to trust, and to teach their young children how to be quiet *like the kapok tree* in order not to attract attention to themselves.

This silence is described in different ways across the Cambodian refugee archive. Sometimes it is framed as a fearful muteness, sometimes as a protective retreat into the mind, sometimes as a numbed speechlessness in response to witnessing death and violence. At night, the Khmer Rouge cadres, their ears to the walls, would circulate outside or beneath Cambodian people's homes, listening for any evidence of disloyalty to the regime. Faced with the Khmer Rouge's panoptic system of surveillance, Cambodian people went quiet.<sup>142</sup> They advised each other, in hushed tones, to say as little as possible. Becoming mute, in addition to becoming blind and deaf, was linked to the protection of one's kin, for Cambodian people knew that the Khmer Rouge targeted entire families and lineages, even babies, to foreclose the future possibility of revenge. As one Khmer Rouge regime slogan went, "To dig up the grass, one must remove even the roots."<sup>143</sup> With nowhere to hide or escape to, people had to hide deeper and deeper within themselves. Planting the kapok tree, metaphorically speaking, thus became a tactic of survival wielded when most other forms of resistance were unavailable. Other Cambodians witnessed such an extremity of violence that they began to turn inward, toward silence, as a means of psychological survival. In her book *From the Land of Shadows*, Khatharya Um explains that the "surrealism" of the Cambodian experience "rendered many first-generation survivors mute, with tongues parched and heavy with pain and rage."<sup>144</sup> At once a protective mechanism against a threat and a response to it, *dam-doeum-kor* is resistant to a straightforward cause-and-effect teleology.

Curiously, the emphasis on *planting* and *rooting* in the Khmer proverb suggests that, even when language seemed to fall away, Cambodian people

still nurtured the possibility of rebirth and regeneration. Silence during Pol Pot time carried an intentionality, a planting of something for an imagined future that was not yet visible. In her book *Unspoken: A Rhetoric of Silence*, the literary scholar Cheryl Glenn writes of silence as a mode of ambiguity against an imposing force, where “unexpected silences unsettle us, often making us anxious about the specific meaning.”<sup>145</sup> This ambiguity of silence can open us up to alternative futures by compelling us to question our own predictions and by refusing the authority of language to explain a complex person or event. In this way, planting the kapok tree reflects a modulation of disability and capacity within necropolitical conditions of genocide, wherein there is a blurring of distinctions between the ontologies of “cannot speak”/“will not speak,” language loss/language presence, silence/speech, or disabled/nondisabled.

In *Refugee Lifeworlds*, I turn to the Cambodian refugee archive to name the planting of the kapok tree as a Khmer epistemology of disability arising specifically from the history of the Cold War in Cambodia and its afterlife. While “epistemology” generally refers to “thought” or “knowledge,”<sup>146</sup> the concept of “ontoepistemology” signals the inherent blurring between epistemology and ontology. As Karen Barad writes: “Practices of knowing and being are not isolable; they are mutually implicated. We don’t obtain knowledge by standing outside the world; we know because we are of the world. We are part of the world in its differential becoming.”<sup>147</sup> In her work, Jasbir Puar likewise blurs epistemology and ontology, calling for a critical shift in our methods from “epistemological corrective to ontological irreducibility.”<sup>148</sup> As a Khmer epistemology of disability, planting the kapok tree grapples with what crip theorists Merri Johnson and Robert McRuer describe as “the instability of ways of knowing from and through forms of pain that may not register as legible impairments, let alone disabilities.”<sup>149</sup> In this way, we might even call planting the kapok tree a “Khmer cripistemology” that eludes Eurocentric definitions of disability. The epistemology of the kapok tree also works to interrupt Cambodia’s Cold War episteme, understood in this book as an ableist, racist, and imperialist knowledge project that reproduces the militaristic violence and rationalities of Cambodia’s Cold War formation.

The kapok tree proverb is both commensurable and incommensurable with the Western medical condition known as “aphasia,” and thus the Cambodian refugee archive might be thought of, in some ways, as an *aphasic refugee archive*. From the Greek etymology *aphatos*, which means to be “speechless” or to be “without language,” aphasia, from a medical perspective, is a condition of language impairment resulting from injury to specific regions of the brain. As a disability, aphasia exists along a spectrum, wherein language may become nonnormative with varying degrees of intensity: speech may come

and go; the ability to comprehend the meaning of a question may suddenly vanish; the words on the page may suddenly go blurry; speech may become perforated, nervous, and stuttering; or language may fall away gradually and then completely. Many Cambodian people live with medical aphasia. At the same time, their conditions of speechlessness, silence, or difficulty speaking that stem from the survival of war and genocide cannot solely be reduced to the medical classification of aphasia. Their “aphasias”—racialized, gendered, and generational—are shaped by social and political contingencies that necessarily exceed medical, diagnostic truth.

As Palestinian writer Adania Shibli asserts, colonial systems do more than simply silence the sufferer: They produce a kind of “perforated language, a language that doesn’t hold itself together.”<sup>150</sup> For Shibli, we can learn a great deal about the experience of violence and its ongoing survival by becoming attuned to the sufferer’s aphasia—to these intervals when “language abandons us,” “when we become speechless, when we miss words, when we scream, when we shout.”<sup>151</sup> Shibli’s articulation about the difficulty of speaking in the afterlife of violence suggests a way in which aphasia might offer a particularly productive entry point for grappling with the lifeworlds of those who do not fit easily into the disabled or nondisabled binary. Other scholars such as Rey Chow have argued that “aphasia . . . can be conceptualized anew as forms of unveiling, as what expose the untenability of ‘proper’ (and proprietary) speech as such.”<sup>152</sup> The aphasic person’s perforated language—full of silences, pauses, hesitations, and inventive substitutions—enacts an embodied, sensorial, relational way of speaking through shared vulnerability that interrupts white, ableist, masculinist hierarchies of valued speech.<sup>153</sup> In Chapter 4 of this book, I consider this aphasic inflection of the Cambodian refugee archive. Where these two criptistemologies of the kapok tree and aphasia differ and/or overlap is not easily parsed. In *Refugee Lifeworlds*, I ask, What happens if we route aphasia through Cambodia and Cambodia through aphasia?

## Khmer Renaissance

The Cambodian refugee archive accesses what in recent decades has been heralded as the “renaissance of the Cambodian arts” or “Khmer renaissance.” In recent years, terms such as “regeneration,” “resurgence,” “brilliance,” “revival,” and others have emerged within global Black, Asian, and Indigenous social justice and artistic movements to characterize community-based responses to the ongoing structures of colonial and settler-colonial violence. The term “renaissance” has perhaps uniquely been attached to the “rebirth” of the arts within Cambodia and the Cambodian diaspora in the post–Cold War era.



This transnational artistic movement harkens back to a Khmer cosmopolitanism and syncretism that characterized the “golden era” in Cambodian history. This was the period immediately after independence from French colonization when Khmer arts and culture flourished—when Phnom Penh was variously known as the “Paris of the East,” the “Pearl of Asia,” and the “Island of Peace” in Southeast Asia. Upon his state visit to Phnom Penh in 1967, Singaporean prime minister Lee Kuan Yew commented that Cambodia’s political neutrality in the Cold War represented “something valuable” that the rest of the world could emulate.<sup>154</sup> Addressing Prince Norodom Sihanouk directly, Yew extolled: “Throughout all the changes of circumstance in the world, your non-aligned policy has never altered its fundamental principles, that the destiny of Cambodia and the Khmers is your paramount consideration.”<sup>155</sup> Additionally, Yew marveled at what Cambodia embodied culturally and aesthetically, describing the country’s mix of cosmopolitan modernity (Phnom Penh “in steel and concrete”) and sublime antiquity (Angkor “in sandstone and laterite”) as “monuments to Khmer creativity.”<sup>156</sup> Given Singapore’s post–Cold War path into the glittering metropolis we know today, it is perhaps most ironic that, in 1967, Yew proclaimed, “I hope, one day, my city will look like this.”<sup>157</sup> *Refugee Lifeworlds* seeks to dwell in that spirit of “Khmer creativity” referenced by Yew and to track its rebirth in the social and artistic movement of the Khmer renaissance.

If the current arts movement can be said to exemplify a Khmer renaissance, this prompts the question of what exactly is being revived and refashioned by the new generation of artists? Between 1960 and 1970, an estimated four hundred Cambodian films were produced, many featuring the big film stars of the time, such as Dy Saveth, Kong Sam Oeun, and Vichara Dany. As Southeast Asian film studies scholar Tilman Baumgärtel explains, “Only around 30 of these films survive, remnants of a national cinema that was full of miracles and beauty: Kings with magic powers, giants, witches, flying horses, gods that walk the earth and a girl with snakes instead of hair are only some of the sensations that the film makers of that time put on the screen despite the very limited technical means that they had at their disposal.”<sup>158</sup> These mythical-themed films proliferated in the 1960s alongside other kinds of Cambodian films—films with modern stories and plots as well as the nation-building films of King Norodom Sihanouk. As the subject of contemporary Cambodian films, such as Davy Chou’s 2011 documentary film *Golden Slumbers* and Sotho Kulikar’s 2014 melodrama *The Last Reel*, the burgeoning film industry of Cambodia’s golden era was “part of a much larger renaissance of Khmer culture in the post-colonial period that included architecture, literature, pop music and visual art.”<sup>159</sup>

Indeed, we have also seen in the Khmer renaissance a revival of the pop music of Cambodia's golden era. Recent films such as John Pirozzi's 2014 *Don't Think I've Forgotten* and Marc Eberle's *Not Easy Rock and Roll*, for example, have sought to recapture a time when Cambodia, particularly the city of Phnom Penh, was frequently regarded as "cool." Pirozzi, who spent over a decade researching and compiling the archival fragments in his film, expressed his motivation to represent in cinema "the one thing that has allowed the Cambodian people to access a time when their life wasn't about war and genocide."<sup>160</sup> Youk Chhang, the director of DC-Cam and an executive producer of *Don't Think I've Forgotten*, has characterized the film as a "completely different way to tell the history than about prison, about killing, about tribunals. . . . It restores the missing part of us, the identity of who we are."<sup>161</sup> As the film demonstrates, Phnom Penh in the 1960s embodied a style of culture influenced by a zeitgeist of free love, progressive thinking, and creative autonomy represented in the nation's hybrid rock and roll music. Cambodia's "coolness" as a musical and cultural haven during the 1960s was produced through its unique geopolitical positioning at the crossroads of European, American, Latin, and Southeast Asian musical influences and circuits of cultural exchange.

To be speaking of the renaissance of Cambodian arts in the present moment almost fifty years after the Cambodian Genocide is a telling signal of the extremity of the repression that took place in the past. The Cold War in Cambodia left not only a devastated national infrastructure but also a void of artistic representation resulting from the Khmer Rouge regime's targeting of writers, musicians, filmmakers, dancers, and other artists. A generation later, Cambodian artists have acquired a degree of psychological space and distance from the traumatic past. Combined with a general acceptance by the international community that Cambodian refugee testimonies were not fabricated tales, time and distance have allowed a new generation of Cambodian artists to approach the past with more experimentation and flexibility. These artists have insisted that Cambodia not be simply conflated with war and genocide.

The renaissance of the Cambodian arts signals, at last, an interval of reprieve for the Cambodian community from the insecurity of perpetual war—a condition necessary for artistic experimentation to take place. And yet, the presence of the genocide is still palpable in contemporary Cambodian writing, reflective of Cambodian author Soth Polin's apt remark that, "even if you are reaching in your imagination for a new destination, you cannot get past their cruelty. When you try to write something without mentioning the Khmer Rouge, you can't."<sup>162</sup> Khmer renaissance does not mean forgetting the past but rather channeling that difficult history into a wholly unique hybrid



**Figure I.7** “The Rising Phoenix,” created in Phnom Penh, Cambodia, 2014. Graffiti blends traditional Kbach Khmer style with contemporary 1960s Cambodian golden era iconography and imagery. (Courtesy of FONKi Yav. Photo by FONKi.)

creative form, mixing the legacy of collective pain and the new generation’s impulse for revival, that could only emerge from Cambodia and the Cambodian diaspora. As FONKi Yav explains in a recent *CBC* television profile, “the wave of that Khmer renaissance” is what propelled him to Cambodia in 2012 to continue his artistic graffiti practice from the land of his parents’ birth. In FONKi’s words, “We had the golden era back in the 60s and then April ‘75 we had our genocide . . . now we’ve been able to heal and we’re witnessing a renaissance not only in the art but in the music, in the film industry. The city’s really developing in its own way. So there’s room now for contemporary art and for us [in the] new generation to get back our history.”<sup>163</sup> FONKi’s graffiti art is distinctive, in particular for its melding of *kbach*—a traditional style of Khmer decorative arts that dates back to the Angkorian era—and 1960s Cambodian golden era iconography and imagery (see Fig. I.7). This syncretism of styles is seen in the example of FONKi’s mural “The Rising Phoenix,” painted in Phnom Penh in 2014, during his first trip back to Cambodia since the completion of his 2012 documentary biopic *The Roots Remain*. “The Rising Phoenix” tethers the present (*kbach* graffiti) to the past (the Khmer mythical figures of the *apsara* and phoenix), generating a fluid and dynamic image of the renaissance and rebirth of Khmer culture. As FONKi has explained, the mural is in “the exact same spot where they erased [his] first version of Kbach Khmer graffiti you see in [his] movie.”<sup>164</sup> Khmer renaissance is marked by both the rebirth of collective identity and the struggle over the

reclamation of public space that has been eroded through over three decades of neoliberal authoritarian rule in Cambodia under Prime Minister Hun Sen.

As the form of graffiti suggests, Khmer renaissance challenges received ideas about art and aesthetic hierarchies. The teleology of presumed “progress” in literary style and form, from testimonial content to avant-garde experimentation, does not hold within the Cambodian context. On this point, I appreciate literary ecocriticism scholar Rob Nixon’s reflection on the false binary often maintained by scholars between the political and the aesthetic. When literary studies become demarcated from critical engagement with worldly issues, Nixon notes, “we frequently witness, alongside an excessive regard for ahistoric philosophy, an accompanying historically indifferent formalism that treats the study of aesthetics as the literary scholar’s definitive calling.”<sup>165</sup> In this branch of literary aesthetics, the study of *literature* is lamented as a disappearing art and “formal categories such as rupture, irony, and bricolage assume an inflated agency.”<sup>166</sup> When this happens, form rather than politics is seen as the literary scholar’s proper purview, and any transgression of the disciplinary boundaries between politics and aesthetics is easily dismissed as sociological or political interpretation. The study of “aesthetics” becomes the specialized domain, “severed from the broader sociopolitical environmental contexts that animate the forms in question.”<sup>167</sup> If there has been in the recent decade an impetus to return to questions of form in literary studies,<sup>168</sup> how can we keep such a turn from lapsing into an abstract, apolitical celebration of the aesthetic, the rhetorical, or the formal? One way of approaching this issue, as Timothy August argues in his book *The Refugee Aesthetic*, is to analyze the refugee narrative on its own terms, “whether it challenges, avoids, or even reinforces [the most] common geopolitical narratives.”<sup>169</sup> Another way of undoing the false binary between politics and aesthetics is to assert, in Saidiya Hartman’s words, that we have a responsibility as scholars and as people of color to find ways “to tell a story capable of engaging and countering the violence of abstraction.”<sup>170</sup> In addressing a topic such as the afterlife of the Cold War in Cambodia, for which there has yet to be a proper reckoning, countering the violence of abstraction by returning to the site of the embodied, the personal, and the political is a way of doing justice to the rich aesthetic dimensions of the Cambodian refugee archive.

The renaissance of the Cambodian arts is a movement propelled not only by the work of Cambodian refugee artists proper but also by those adjacent to the community. Many of the authors, artists, and filmmakers whose works I discuss in this book—Viet Thanh Nguyen, Madeleine Thien, and Masahiro Sugano—are not of Cambodian ancestry. As authors, their engagement with the Cambodian community and the legacies of the Cold War in Cambodia

resides in their struggles with what Trinh T. Minh-ha calls “speaking nearby”—a form of “speaking that does not objectify, does not point to an object as if it is distant from the speaking subject or absent from the speaking place.”<sup>171</sup> Speaking nearby “reflects on itself and can come very close to a subject without, however, seizing or claiming it.”<sup>172</sup> This position of ethical proximity, as opposed to appropriation, is sustained through not only what the writer chooses to tell but also how the form or style employed can resist a voyeuristic or appropriative gaze. To speak nearby “is not just a technique or a statement to be made verbally. It is an attitude in life, a way of positioning oneself in relation to the world.”<sup>173</sup> Speaking nearby the Cambodian community entails the cultivation of a lifelong ethics and commitment to dialogue, a respect of privacy and mental health, and a prioritization of relationality over monetization or cultural currency.

This persistent accountability to the ethics and politics of speaking nearby is perhaps best articulated by acclaimed author Madeleine Thien, a Canadian author of Malaysian-Chinese ancestry, in an interview about why she chose to write a book about Cambodia: “I hoped that *Dogs at the Perimeter* would be able to stand behind the historical and witnessing books, to say that all of us have a stake in understanding what happened there, that we are all connected.”<sup>174</sup> Time and again, Thien has underscored the point that Cambodia’s twentieth-century tragedy must be understood as a global event connected to the world. “The history of the Cambodian Genocide,” Thien asserts, “is also American history, and is inextricable from the repercussions of American policies and decisions. We need to look at it, think about it, mourn it, be angry about it, and at least live in it for a little while.”<sup>175</sup> In the Global North, where Cambodia’s collective tragedy was witnessed from a distance, the public still has a stake in revisiting Cambodia’s history for a multitude of reasons: among them, the fact that the United States was complicit in bombing Cambodia; that many Western intellectuals and journalists were apologists for a genocidal regime; that the world remained largely apathetic to the plight of an entire nation that suffered on an unprecedented level. As Thien has stated, *Dogs at the Perimeter* was propelled by her belief that “there is no us and them, we are all entwined and responsible to one another. Geopolitics and the movement of people across borders has made this so.”<sup>176</sup> For Thien, then, the difficulty of reckoning with Cambodian history is a responsibility that must be carried by Cambodians and non-Cambodians alike.

This view of the need to distribute the labor of reckoning is also articulated in Rithy Panh’s *The Missing Picture*, which ends with the narrator saying, “And so, I make this picture . . . this missing picture I now hand over to you, so that it never ceases to seek us out.”<sup>177</sup> The responsibility to remember



cannot be the duty of the survivor to bear alone. For decades now, Cambodian survivors and their descendants have labored to assert that our histories cannot be reduced to the material of mere footnote, anecdote, or silence. As Panh writes in *The Elimination*, for Cambodian survivors, the return to the past “isn’t some sad passion; it’s a struggle against elimination . . . it gives us back our humanity, our intelligence, our history.”<sup>178</sup> We search for a language and form that can give meaning to the dark void of the past because we do not want to be stranded there, alone at the edge of that mass grave.

## Outline

*Refugee Lifeworlds* unfolds across four chapters and a coda. The book has a temporal structure as it moves (in a nonlinear way at times) through the chronological periods of the Cold War in Cambodia from the U.S. bombing of Cambodia (1965–1975), to the Cambodian Genocide (1975–1979), to the history of Cambodian refugee resettlement (1979–present). There is also a spatial movement throughout the book that traces the Cambodian refugee’s transpacific passage from Cambodia to the United States/Canada and back to Cambodia again. Finally, each chapter develops my theory of refugee lifeworlds a little differently by bringing a specific aspect of critical disability studies (namely, the concepts of debility, cripistemology, and aphasia) to the analysis of the Cambodian refugee archive.

A framing chapter for the book, Chapter 1, “Cambodia’s Cold War Episteme,” examines the construction and circulation of racial fantasies of Cambodia from the colonial French protectorate era to the present. Cambodia’s Cold War episteme operates through the repetition of a familiar set of orientalist and racist repertoires as well as what I call the logic of minor anecdoting. This is the invocation of Cambodia as a “minor detail” in the narration of something else—the “main story”—that is expressly *not* about Cambodia or Cambodian people. The logic of minor anecdoting renders Cambodia simultaneously hypervisible as a frame of reference and mystifyingly opaque and unknowable as a site of meaning and knowledge unto itself. Cambodia’s Cold War episteme also disavows the disability and pain of Cambodia through the inscription of colonial tropes about the Cambodian body-mind as outside of the teleologies of Western modernity and liberal progress—as exotic, savage, and damaged matter. I track this episteme across different texts and archives such as Cold War photojournalism, the 1970s Henry Kissinger telecons, Joel Brinkley’s 2011 *Cambodia’s Curse*, the French 1906 Colonial Exposition in Marseille, and the form of the “Cambodia travel anecdote.” These works illustrate how Cambodia’s Cold War episteme operates

not only to sustain the ongoing debilitation of Cambodian populations but also to shore up the capacitated humanity of white liberal personhood seen as the antithesis to this population marked as always already defective.

Chapter 2, “Debility and the U.S. Bombing of Cambodia” examines the intersection between disability and refugee life in relation to the U.S. secret war in Cambodia, an “off the map,” disavowed coordinate in the U.S. imperial cartography of the Cold War. I examine the *longue durée* of endemic debilitation produced through the U.S. bombing of Cambodia as an imperial formation coextensive with the global Cold War confrontation. Debility in the context of the U.S. bombing of Cambodia and its afterlife is multivalent: It relates to the incapacitation of Cambodian populations subjected to the brunt of the U.S. war machine’s imperial violence and “right to maim,” to the predation of the Khmer Rouge war machine as this regime sought to recruit disposed of and disenfranchised populations to the cause of Communist revolution, to the extraction and deployment of the Black American body’s soldiering labor as war fodder for the front lines of the war in Southeast Asia, to the reproduction of ableist fantasies of military masculinity and disability economies of humanitarian labor, and, finally, to the ongoing crip incarcerations and displacements of the Cambodian American refugee-deportee. Through their narrativization of the U.S. bombing of Cambodia and its long afterlife, texts such as Rithy Panh’s film *Shiiku, the Catch*, Viet Thanh Nguyen’s short story “The Americans,” and Kosal Khiev / Masahiro Sugano’s film *Cambodian Son* illuminate how debility operates by suturing the operations of war to the racial capitalist accumulation of bodies made available for injury and maiming.

In Chapter 3, “Crippling the Kapok Tree and the Cambodian Genocide,” I address the disabling legacies of the Cambodian Genocide through attention to the Khmer proverb “to plant a kapok tree,” a Khmer idiom of disability that means “see nothing, hear nothing, say nothing.” Reading this proverb as a composite of being blind, deaf, and mute, I argue the kapok tree makes visible the multilayered valences of Cambodian people’s forms of “emotional resistance” (*kamleang chet*) during Pol Pot time. Inclusive of an array of corporeal, affective, and psychological tactics—such as intentional blindness, deafness, and muteness—the situated practices of emotional resistance and performative disability adopted by Cambodian people during the genocide continue to remain illegible within Western paradigms of resistance and subversion. In this chapter, I bring crip theory to bear on a reading of the Cambodian refugee archive, as exemplified by works such as Vaddey Ratner’s novel *In the Shadow of the Banyan* and Rithy Panh’s film *The Missing Picture*. I argue that the kapok tree can be seen as opening us up to a Khmer

cripistemological way of knowing refugee disability in the afterlife of the Cold War in Cambodia.

Chapter 4, “Aphasia and the Nervous Condition of Refugee Asylum,” explores the psychic and affective refugee afterlives of the Cold War in Cambodia. Aphasia has been theorized as both a speech impairment resulting from brain injury and a socially and racially inflected condition of being made speechless in moments of racial violence and destabilization. Through analyzing Madeleine Thien’s novel *Dogs at the Perimeter* and short story “Alice Munro Country,” this chapter brings disability studies to bear on refugee lifeworlds by theorizing *refugee aphasia* as a critical tool that accounts for the ruptures of silence and speechlessness in the Cambodian refugee archive, and considers what this aphasic form might mean. Unsettling the disabled/non-disabled binary, refugee aphasia, I argue, can be read as an ontoepistemology of refugee being and knowing that arises in the afterlife of war and genocide.

Finally, in the book’s Coda, I conclude with a discussion on the afterlife of the Cold War in Cambodia in the longer genealogy of U.S. permanent war, from Cambodia to Iraq, Afghanistan, and Syria. The Coda ends with a personal essay of refugee autotheory titled “Boneyards of the Cold War.” This essay is a reflection on my experience of walking through the War Museum Cambodia in Siem Reap—a boneyard of decommissioned war material leftover from the Cold War in Cambodia. As I move through this unsettling space, I find myself captivated by the image of a lotus flower taking root in a bomb crater. What grows in the ruins of war? This remains an open and indefinite question by the book’s end.

My mother often tells me the story of how she saved her husband, my father.

In 1976, my family lived in a *pom*, a village in the jungle created by clearing the bush and building huts made of bamboo. One day, my father was sent to work in a work cooperative with a group of around fifteen other men. My mother, a twenty-eight-year-old woman, stayed at home with their two young children, my brothers. It took the group two days to walk through the dense jungle to the work site. Many could not endure the unremitting labor, the harsh tropical elements, and the lack of food. One by one, people died of exhaustion and illness. After days or weeks, only about five men returned to the *pom*. My father was not among them.

Hearing rumors that my father was ill, my mother begged the village leader to let her go see him. The cadre felt pity for my mother and gave her a transit letter to walk to the work site to see about my father. She walked for days, by herself, through the jungle, foraging for food along the way, stopping to rest and

to sleep on the earth. When she arrived at the work site, she found my father, gravely ill, left outside under a tree, where they left people to die. He was unconscious, on the brink of death, but his heart was still beating. She pleaded with the work cooperative leader to transport my father to a hospital in Kampong Thom. “Please, look, he’s still alive,” she said. Eventually, they agreed to transport him. The vehicle arrived, full of Khmer Rouge soldiers. They stopped my mother from entering the vehicle, pointing a rifle at her and ordering her to stop. She got down on her knees and begged them to let her go with them. Somehow, miraculously, they agreed. She traveled in the vehicle with the Khmer Rouge soldiers, protecting my father’s unconscious body.

The city of Kampong Thom, her hometown, was barely recognizable—a ghost town, almost empty. The hospital was scarcely a hospital. The sick and dying laid on flat wooden beds. Some patients were given basic IVs, but modern medicine was not available. My mother sat on the floor at my father’s bedside waiting for him to regain consciousness. She thought of her children back at the *pom*, sent out daily to work in the children’s work cooperative. She thought of her youngest son who was frail and showing signs of dysentery. How much longer would he survive?

Two or three days passed before my father finally stirred. He had regained consciousness, but it would be three months before he left the hospital. My mother could not stay. She had to return to her children. She made the journey on foot, alone, through the jungle. It took her an entire day to walk back to the *pom*.

“No one would believe how people survived in Pol Pot time,” my mother says as she ends this story.